

BATTLE ZONE Akhilesh Yadav joins Rahul Gandhi's BJNY rally in Agra, Feb. 25; (inset) SP chief whip Manoj Pandey who crossvoted in the RS poll

agreed to the SP's offer". Sources in the Congress hinted that it may request SP to exchange Shravasti and Lakhimpur with Mathura and Bulandshahr.

The SP has lost two of its main allies—the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) and the Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP)—since its decent show in the 2022 UP assembly poll, when it raised its tally from 47 to 111 seats. As for the Congress, it has seen a steady erosion in support in the past few elections. In the 2019 LS poll, it managed just one seat, Rae Bareli, where Sonia Gandhi won. Rahul had lost in family pocket borough Amethi (to the BJP's Smriti Irani) despite the SP and BSP not fielding a candidate there.

Indeed, a turnaround for the Congress seems a monumental task. In 2019, the BJP had won 14 of the 17 seats that have come to the Congress now, 11 of them with over 50 per cent vote share. The latter, on the other hand, could not manage even 10 per cent of the vote in nine of these 17 seats. Beyond the math, the Congress-SP alliance needs to be in sync, not just to ensure transfer of votes but also to attract new voters. Sources in the Congress say several senior leaders, including Salman Khurshid, Rajesh Mishra and Brijlal Khabri, are unhappy as seats in their fief have gone to the SP.

Another challenge is communal polarisation. In the past few years, whenever two Opposition parties have got together in UP, the BJP has been able to project it as an 'unholy alliance' to consolidate the Muslim vote. The SP-Congress must neutralise this narrative while also relaying a message of uniting the PDAs (Pichada, Dalit and Alpsankhyak) or Backwards, Dalits and minorities (especially Muslims). It's an uphill task and the two parties will not want to dwell on their last disastrous outing together—the 2017 debacle that installed Yogi in Lucknow. ■

KERALA

LEFT TAKES THE LEAD

By Jeemon Jacob



ANI

EARLY START Kerala CM and CPI(M) leader Pinarayi Vijayan

Looking to avoid a repeat of 2019, the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) in Kerala has announced candidates early for the coming general election. The CPI(M) candidates' list has a number of heavyweights, including politburo member A. Vijayaraghavan in Palakkad, ex-finance minister Dr Thomas Isaac in Pathanamthitta, and the former health minister who did such a stellar job during Covid, K.K. Shailaja Teacher, in Vadakara. Ally CPI, too, has upped their game, fielding Annie Raja (wife of party general secretary D. Raja) in Wayanad, where the sitting Congress MP is Rahul Gandhi.

Coming to Rahul and the Congress, sources say the 'will-he-won't-he' contest again from Kerala is keeping the state unit on tenterhooks. In 2019, the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) had swept the state, winning 19 of the 20 LS seats, on the back of Rahul's entry in Wayanad. UDF constituent IUML (Indian Union Muslim League), though, has announced their candidates. Among the IUML contests to look out for will be the one between two-time MP Abdussamad Samadani and the CPI(M)'s K.S. Hamsa in Ponnani. The latter is a former IUML